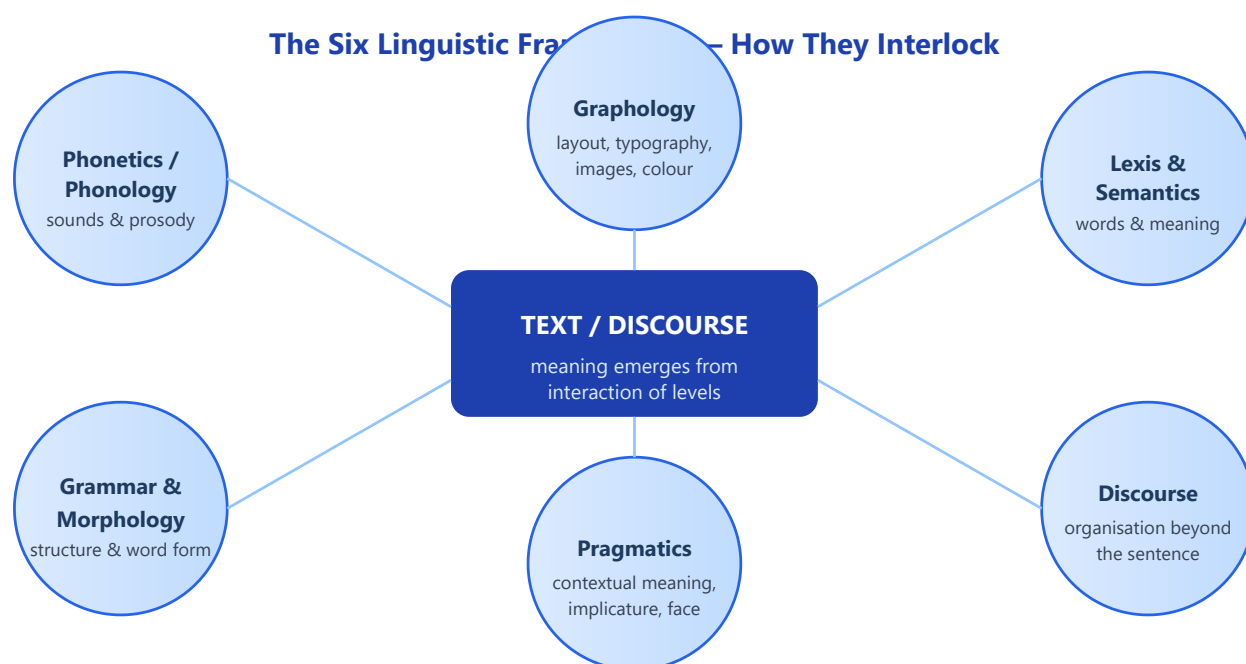


- RAG Learning

# 1.1 Methods of Language Analysis

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 1: Language, the Individual and Society — Section 3.1.2

The **six linguistic frameworks** (also called **levels of analysis**) are the toolkit AQA expects you to apply to any text. They are: **phonetics, phonology & prosodics; graphology; lexis & semantics; grammar & morphology; pragmatics; discourse**. Top-band answers integrate levels rather than listing features at each level in isolation.



## 1.1.1 Phonetics, Phonology and Prosodics

**Phonetics** is the study of how speech sounds are physically produced (articulated) and perceived. **Phonology** is the study of how sounds function within the system of a particular language — which sound contrasts carry meaning. **Prosodics** concerns the suprasegmental features of speech: stress, intonation, tempo, rhythm, pause and volume.

The smallest unit phonology works with is the **phoneme** — a sound that distinguishes meaning. English has around 44 phonemes (numbers vary by dialect). A **minimal pair** is two words differing by only one phoneme, proving that the two sounds are distinct units: *pit* /pɪt/ vs *bit* /bɪt/. Only the initial consonant differs, yet the meanings are different.

## Consonant classification

Consonants are classified by three features:

1. **Place of articulation** — where in the mouth the airflow is obstructed (e.g. *bilabial* both lips, *alveolar* tongue against the alveolar ridge, *velar* back of tongue against the soft palate).
2. **Manner of articulation** — how the airflow is obstructed (*plosive/stop*, *fricative*, *affricate*, *nasal*, *approximant*, *lateral*).
3. **Voicing** — whether the vocal folds vibrate (*voiced*) or not (*voiceless*).

| Sound | IPA  | Example | Classification                    |
|-------|------|---------|-----------------------------------|
| p     | /p/  | pit     | Voiceless bilabial plosive        |
| b     | /b/  | bit     | Voiced bilabial plosive           |
| f     | /f/  | fan     | Voiceless labiodental fricative   |
| v     | /v/  | van     | Voiced labiodental fricative      |
| sh    | /ʃ/  | ship    | Voiceless post-alveolar fricative |
| ch    | /tʃ/ | chip    | Voiceless post-alveolar affricate |
| m     | /m/  | man     | Voiced bilabial nasal             |
| ng    | /ŋ/  | sing    | Voiced velar nasal                |

## Vowels

Vowels are made without obstruction of airflow and are classified by tongue height (high/close vs low/open), tongue position (front vs back), and lip rounding. English has **monophthongs** (single vowel sounds: /ɪ/ in *bit*) and **diphthongs** (two vowel qualities glided together: /aɪ/ in *time*).

Regional variation is often concentrated in vowels — the *bath/trap* split distinguishes Northern and Southern British English.

## Prosodic features you should recognise

| Feature           | Definition                                           | Why it matters                                                                                             |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Stress</b>     | Emphasis placed on a syllable or word                | Changes word class ( <i>RE</i> cord vs re <i>CORD</i> ) and focuses meaning within a sentence.             |
| <b>Intonation</b> | Pitch pattern across an utterance                    | Rising intonation typically marks questions or checks; falling intonation signals completion or authority. |
| <b>Tempo</b>      | Speed of delivery                                    | Fast speech can signal excitement or nervousness; slow speech can convey gravity, hesitation or emphasis.  |
| <b>Volume</b>     | Loudness                                             | Shouting vs whispering encodes emotion and power relations.                                                |
| <b>Pause</b>      | Silence within speech (micro (.) or timed (2.0))     | Marks planning time, face-saving, turn-giving or dramatic effect.                                          |
| <b>Rhythm</b>     | Temporal patterning of stressed/unstressed syllables | English is a stress-timed language — triadic rhythm ("blood, sweat, tears") is rhetorically powerful.      |

**Exam Tip:** You are not expected to be a trained phonetician. What examiners want is that you can identify and comment on the *effect* of sound features — alliteration, assonance, onomatopoeia, sibilance, plosiveness — and of prosodic choices in transcripts (stress, intonation, pauses). Always link the feature to meaning or audience effect.

## 1.1.2 Graphology

**Graphology** is the visual appearance and organisation of a written text. It includes typography, font choice, colour, layout, spacing, images, punctuation as visual feature, and the relationship between text and non-textual elements on the page or screen.

Historically, graphology was sometimes dismissed as secondary to "real" linguistic analysis. At A-level, you must treat graphological choices as meaningful. A tabloid front page, a perfume advert, a Government leaflet and a personal text message all rely heavily on graphology to position the reader.

## Key graphological features

- **Typography** — font family (serif vs sans-serif), weight (bold), style (italic), size, case.
- **Colour** — foreground/background contrast, brand colours, symbolic associations (red = urgency/passion, blue = trust/calm).
- **Layout** — columns, alignment, hierarchy (headlines, subheads, body), use of white space.
- **Images** — photographs, illustrations, icons; relationship to surrounding text (anchoring, relay).
- **Visual punctuation** — bullet points, dashes, exclamation marks used decoratively.
- **Orthographic play** — deliberate mis-spelling for effect (e.g. *Krispy Kreme*), use of emoji, capitals as shouting in digital writing.

**Applied Example:** A news website uses a large bold serif headline in black, a single colour photograph, and a short Anglo-Saxon, monosyllabic strap-line. The serif font connotes authority and tradition; the black-on-white contrast signals seriousness; the photograph anchors meaning emotionally. Graphology works *with* lexis and syntax to construct a particular register and position the reader as a thoughtful citizen rather than an entertainment-seeker.

## 1.1.3 Lexis and Semantics

**Lexis** refers to the vocabulary of a language — the set of words available to speakers.

**Semantics** is the study of meaning conveyed by lexis and by larger linguistic units.

## Lexical classifications

| Classification             | Details                                                                                    | Example / Effect                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Word class</b>          | Noun, verb, adjective, adverb, pronoun, preposition, conjunction, determiner, interjection | Distribution of word classes indicates register — heavy nouns + adjectives = descriptive; heavy verbs + adverbs = dynamic narrative.                    |
| <b>Etymological origin</b> | Anglo-Saxon (Germanic), Latinate, Greek, French-Norman, borrowings                         | Anglo-Saxon "home", "dog", "work" feels direct and everyday; Latinate "residence", "canine", "occupation" feels formal, elevated.                       |
| <b>Register</b>            | Formal, informal, colloquial, slang, taboo, archaic, technical/jargon                      | A text's register positions the reader as insider or outsider of a social group.                                                                        |
| <b>Frequency</b>           | High-frequency (everyday) vs low-frequency (specialist / literary)                         | Low-frequency lexis reduces accessibility but can signal prestige or expertise.                                                                         |
| <b>Field</b>               | Topic or domain (sport, medicine, finance, warfare, religion)                              | A semantic field frames the subject ideologically — describing a political debate in the semantic field of warfare ("attack", "defend") is not neutral. |

## Semantic relations

- **Synonyms** — similar meanings (*brave, courageous, valiant*). Near-synonyms differ in register or connotation.
- **Antonyms** — opposite meanings. *Gradable* (hot/cold), *complementary* (alive/dead), *relational* (buy/sell).
- **Hyponymy** — hierarchical relationships. *Rose* is a hyponym of *flower*; *flower* is the hypernym.
- **Meronymy** — part-whole relationships. *Wheel* is a meronym of *car*.
- **Polysemy** — one word, multiple related meanings (*foot* of a mountain / of a person).

- **Homonymy** — one form, unrelated meanings: *bank* (river) / *bank* (financial).

## Denotation vs Connotation

**Denotation** is the dictionary definition. **Connotation** is the bundle of associations a word carries — often cultural, emotional or ideological. Writers exploit connotation: describing a politician as "*stubborn*" rather than "*determined*" signals different evaluation even if denotationally similar.

## Figurative language — key tropes

- **Metaphor** — implicit comparison: *time is a thief*.
- **Simile** — explicit comparison using *like* or *as*: *quick as a flash*.
- **Personification** — giving human attributes to non-human: *the wind howled*.
- **Metonymy** — using one thing to stand for a related thing: *the Crown* for the monarchy.
- **Synecdoche** — part for whole or whole for part: *all hands on deck*.
- **Hyperbole** — exaggeration: *I've told you a thousand times*.
- **Understatement / litotes** — deliberate downplay: *not bad* (= very good).
- **Euphemism** — softened substitute: *passed away* for *died*.
- **Dysphemism** — deliberately harsh substitute for polite form.

**Exam Tip:** Avoid feature-spotting. "The writer uses a metaphor" is AO1 at its weakest. "The metaphor *time is a thief* constructs time as an antagonist who takes from us, framing ageing in a semantic field of theft and loss" links feature to meaning — this is what AO1 and AO3 together reward.

## 1.1.4 Grammar and Morphology

**Grammar** is the system of rules describing how words combine into phrases, clauses and sentences. **Morphology** is the study of word formation — how morphemes combine to build words.

## Morphemes

A **morpheme** is the smallest unit of meaning. Morphemes are classed as:

- **Free morphemes** — stand alone: *cat, run, happy*.
- **Bound morphemes** — must attach: *-s, -ed, un-, re-, -able, -ness*.
- **Inflectional morphemes** — mark grammatical information without changing word class (*cats, walked, taller*).
- **Derivational morphemes** — create new words, often changing class (*happy* → *happiness*; *teach* → *teacher*).

Example breakdown: **un-forget-able** = *un-* (bound, negating) + *forget* (free) + *-able* (bound, converting to adjective) — three morphemes.

## Word classes

| Class              | Function                                                                                             | Examples                               |
|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| <b>Noun</b>        | Names people, places, things, ideas. Counts as common/proper, concrete/abstract, count/mass.         | <i>tree, London, freedom, water</i>    |
| <b>Verb</b>        | Describes action, process or state. Main / auxiliary (be, have, do) / modal (can, must, should).     | <i>run, is, have, should</i>           |
| <b>Adjective</b>   | Modifies nouns. Can be gradable (comparative/superlative).                                           | <i>small, smaller, smallest</i>        |
| <b>Adverb</b>      | Modifies verbs, adjectives or other adverbs. Express manner, time, place, degree, frequency.         | <i>quickly, yesterday, very, often</i> |
| <b>Pronoun</b>     | Replaces noun phrases. Personal / possessive / reflexive / demonstrative / relative / interrogative. | <i>I, mine, myself, this, who</i>      |
| <b>Preposition</b> | Relates a noun phrase to another element (time, place, manner).                                      | <i>in, on, after, despite</i>          |

|                     |                                                                                                       |                       |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| <b>Conjunction</b>  | Joins words, phrases, clauses. Coordinating (and, but, or) / subordinating (although, because, when). | <i>and, although</i>  |
| <b>Determiner</b>   | Specifies a noun phrase. Articles (a, the), demonstratives, possessives, quantifiers, numerals.       | <i>the, my, three</i> |
| <b>Interjection</b> | Expressive exclamation, grammatically detached.                                                       | <i>oh!, wow, hey</i>  |

## Phrases, clauses and sentences

- **Noun phrase (NP)** — determiner + (pre-modifiers) + head noun + (post-modifier). E.g. *[the three small red boxes on the table]*.
- **Verb phrase (VP)** — main verb, optionally with auxiliaries: *[has been working]*.
- **Clause** — contains a subject and a finite verb. A main clause stands alone; a subordinate clause depends on another.
- **Sentence types:**
  - **Simple** — one main clause: *The dog barked.*
  - **Compound** — two main clauses joined by coordinator: *The dog barked and the cat ran.*
  - **Complex** — main clause + subordinate clause: *The dog barked when the doorbell rang.*
  - **Compound-complex** — multiple main + subordinate.
  - **Minor** — lacks finite verb: *Fantastic. / Why?*

## Sentence functions

- **Declarative** — statement (*It's raining.*)
- **Interrogative** — question (*Is it raining?*)
- **Imperative** — command (*Take an umbrella.*)
- **Exclamatory** — exclamation (*What a downpour!*)

## Voice: active vs passive

Active: *The council demolished the building.* Passive: *The building was demolished (by the council).* The passive lets the writer foreground the patient and optionally hide the agent — a frequent device in news reports ("Mistakes were made") and scientific writing (impersonal objectivity).

## Clause-structure elements (SPOCA)

- **S** — Subject (who/what the clause is about)
- **P** — Predicator (main verb)
- **O** — Object (direct / indirect)
- **C** — Complement (follows a linking verb; describes subject or object)
- **A** — Adverbial (information about time, place, manner, reason)

Example: *[She]<sub>S</sub> [gave]<sub>P</sub> [him]<sub>O</sub> [a book]<sub>O</sub> [yesterday]<sub>A</sub>.*

**Exam Tip:** Top-band AO1 always labels grammatical features precisely *and* connects them to meaning. "The writer front-loads the temporal adverbial *Yesterday* to foreground when the event happened" is worth more than "the writer uses an adverbial".

## 1.1.5 Pragmatics

**Pragmatics** is the study of meaning in context — how listeners and readers infer what a speaker or writer *intends* beyond what is literally said. It draws on shared knowledge, social relationships, politeness norms and cultural expectations.

### Speech acts (Austin, Searle)

- **Locutionary act** — the literal utterance.
- **Illocutionary force** — the intended function (request, promise, apology, warning...).
- **Perlocutionary effect** — the actual effect on the hearer.

"*Could you pass the salt?*" is literally a question about ability (locutionary) but functions as a polite request (illocutionary). Its perlocutionary effect is, hopefully, the salt being passed.

Speech acts can be **direct** (form matches function: *Give me the salt.*) or **indirect** (form differs from function: *Could you pass the salt?*). Indirect speech acts are a key politeness resource.

### Grice's Cooperative Principle

H.P. Grice proposed that conversation is cooperative, governed by four **maxims**:

| Maxim           | Principle                                                  | Flouting example                                                                    |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Quantity</b> | Give the right amount of information — not more, not less. | A: "How was the party?" B: "There was food." — implies the party was underwhelming. |
| <b>Quality</b>  | Be truthful; don't say what you believe to be false.       | Sarcasm: "What a lovely day!" in a thunderstorm.                                    |
| <b>Relation</b> | Be relevant.                                               | A: "Are you coming?" B: "It's raining." — flouts relation to communicate refusal.   |
| <b>Manner</b>   | Be clear, brief and orderly; avoid ambiguity.              | Deliberately vague language in politics; hedging in bad news.                       |

When a maxim is **flouted**, the hearer infers an **implicature** — the extra meaning the speaker intends.

## Politeness theory (Brown & Levinson)

Every speaker has two aspects of **face**:

- **Positive face** — the desire to be liked, approved of, included.
- **Negative face** — the desire not to be imposed on, to have autonomy.

A **face-threatening act (FTA)** (e.g. a request, criticism, refusal) risks one or both. Politeness strategies mitigate:

- **Positive politeness** — attending to positive face: compliments, inclusive "we", shared jokes.
- **Negative politeness** — attending to negative face: hedges ("sort of", "maybe"), indirect requests, apologies, modalised forms ("Could you possibly...").
- **Off-record** — hinting rather than asserting ("It's freezing in here" = close the window).

## Deixis

**Deictic** expressions take their reference from the context of utterance:

- **Personal deixis** — *I, you, we*.

- **Spatial deixis** — *here, there, this, that*.
- **Temporal deixis** — *now, then, yesterday, tomorrow*.
- **Social deixis** — honorifics, address forms (*sir, mate*).

Deixis is economical but utterly context-bound. A transcript read out of context is often uninterpretable.

## 1.1.6 Discourse

**Discourse** is language beyond the sentence. Discourse analysis considers how whole texts are organised, how they cohere, how conversations unfold, and how genre conventions shape expectations.

### Cohesion and coherence

**Cohesion** is the set of grammatical and lexical ties that link sentences. **Coherence** is the overall sense that a text hangs together logically. A cohesive text is not automatically coherent, but coherence usually requires cohesion.

| Cohesive device     | Explanation                                                     | Example                                                                                |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Reference</b>    | Pronouns, demonstratives that point to other parts of the text. | <i>Harriet bought a phone. <u>It</u> had a large screen.</i> (anaphoric — points back) |
| <b>Substitution</b> | Replacing one item with another to avoid repetition.            | <i>I need a pen. Do you have <u>one</u>?</i>                                           |
| <b>Ellipsis</b>     | Omitting words understood from context.                         | A: "Coming?" B: "[I am coming,] Yes."                                                  |
| <b>Conjunction</b>  | Logical connectors between sentences/clauses.                   | <i>However, Furthermore, Therefore, Although.</i>                                      |

|                         |                                       |                                                                                 |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Lexical cohesion</b> | Repetition, synonyms, semantic field. | <i>phone ... screen ... battery ... camera</i><br>(field of mobile technology). |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## Turn-taking and conversation analysis

Sacks, Schegloff and Jefferson proposed that conversation proceeds through **turn-construction units**. Key concepts:

- **Adjacency pairs** — two-part exchanges: greeting/greeting, question/answer, invitation/acceptance.
- **Preferred vs dispreferred responses** — a refusal is usually delayed, mitigated, and accompanied by explanation.
- **Transition-relevance places** — points where a listener may take a turn without being considered rude.
- **Overlaps vs interruptions** — overlaps are brief and usually cooperative; interruptions violate the current speaker's turn.
- **Back-channelling** — minimal responses ("mm", "yeah") that show continued engagement.

## Non-fluency features of spontaneous speech

- **Fillers**: *er, um, erm* — planning time.
- **False starts** — speaker begins, then restarts.
- **Repetitions** — "I was — I was going to say".
- **Self-repairs** — correcting mid-sentence.
- **Discourse markers** — *well, like, you know, so, anyway* — organise the flow of talk.
- **Uptalk** (HRT — high rising terminal) — rising intonation on declaratives, often signals tentativeness.

## Halliday's metafunctions

M.A.K. Halliday argued that every utterance simultaneously performs three functions:

- **Ideational** — representing experience (content, processes, participants).
- **Interpersonal** — enacting relationships (stance, politeness, authority).

- **Textual** — organising the message into coherent discourse (cohesion, theme/rheme, graphology).

This is a hugely useful essay framework: for any text, ask *what does it represent? how does it position the reader? how is it organised?* Each of these maps onto several of the six levels.

**Exam Tip:** For the exam, integrate frameworks. A single paragraph might analyse an extract's *lexis* (emotive monosyllabic Anglo-Saxon), *grammar* (declaratives + fronted adverbials), *pragmatics* (inclusive "we" creating positive face), and *graphology* (bold headlines) to show a coordinated persuasive register. That joined-up analysis distinguishes the top bands.

## 1.1.7 Applying the Frameworks — Structured Method

A reliable way to approach any Paper 1 Section A analysis is the **AFPM** planning acronym. For every text:

1. **Audience** — who is this for? How is the audience positioned?
2. **Function/Purpose** — to inform, persuade, entertain, instruct, express, build rapport?
3. **Purpose effects** — which frameworks foreground that purpose?
4. **Mode** — spoken, written, electronic, multimodal? What conventions apply?

Then write analytical paragraphs that integrate two or more frameworks per point, *always* linked to audience, purpose and effect. Use precise terminology; use quotations; use comparative structure when paired texts are given.

**Applied Example:** Opening sentence of an analytical paragraph: "*The writer constructs a register of intimate authority by juxtaposing low-frequency Latinate lexis ('unprecedented', 'epistemology') with inclusive first-person-plural pronouns ('we', 'our'), a strategy which flatters the reader's intellect while positioning them alongside the speaker on matters of public importance.*" — notice the integration of lexis + grammar + pragmatics + effect on audience, all in one sentence.

## Key Terms Checklist

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Make sure you can define and give an example of each: **phoneme, minimal pair, prosodic feature, graphology, lexis, semantic field, register, denotation, connotation, morpheme (free/bound, inflectional/derivational), noun phrase, modal auxiliary, declarative / interrogative / imperative / exclamatory, active vs passive, subordinate clause, cohesion, deixis, speech act (direct/indirect), Grice's maxims, implicature, face (positive/negative), politeness strategies, adjacency pair, turn-taking, back-channel, non-fluency features, Halliday's metafunctions, idiolect, sociolect.**